



RABBIT · *ORYCTOLAGUS CUNICULUS*

Keep your rabbit the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: real space instead of a hutch, the hay-first diet that prevents most of what goes wrong, GI stasis caught early, and the routines that keep a rabbit thriving for its full lifespan.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every measurement in feet and metres, every portion by body weight
- ✓ Two full pages on GI stasis, the emergency that kills most pet rabbits
- ✓ The peer-reviewed case for a bonded companion, and how to bond one
- ✓ Printable emergency card, pet-sitter sheet, and a droppings reference

40 pages

Beginner to Intermediate

Print or tablet

Version 2.1 · Sep 2026



CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
-------------------------	---

SECTION 01 · QUICK PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
-------------------------------	---

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Housing & Space	5
Flooring, Litter Training & Rabbit-Proofing	6
Indoors, Outdoors & Temperature	7
Diet: Hay First	8
Greens, Pellets & the Never-Feed List	9
Feeding by Life Stage	10
Handling: Picking a Rabbit Up	11
Building Trust & Reading a Rabbit	12
Common Mistakes	13
Enrichment: What the Research Says	14
Bonding & Companionship	15
Spay, Neuter & Why It Isn't Optional	16

SECTION 03 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Health Red Flags & the Rabbit-Savvy Vet	17
GI Stasis: Recognizing It	18
GI Stasis: Warning Signs	19
GI Stasis: Treatment & Prevention	20
Dental Disease	21
Flystrike & Snuffles	22
E. cuniculi, Sore Hocks, Bladder Sludge & RHDV2	23
Grooming, Nails & Molting	24
Reading Droppings & Cecotropes	25

SECTION 04 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	26
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	27

SECTION 05 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget & Shopping List	28
First 30 Days Checklist	29
Symptom Quick Reference	30
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	31
Power Outages & the Blackout Plan	32
Travel, Transport & Moving	33
Pet-Sitter Sheet	34
Owner Log	35
Equipment, Vet & Bonding Log	36
Enrichment Checklist & Log	37

REFERENCE

Glossary	38
Sources & Further Reading	39
Version History & About	40

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 10 in order before buying anything, and read page 16 before you buy the rabbit. Two decisions cost the most to reverse: how much space the rabbit gets, and whether it is spayed or neutered. The pet aisle will sell you a cage that is a fraction of what a rabbit needs, and an unspayed female carries a cancer risk high enough that vets treat the surgery as close to routine. Get both right first, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 28.

If your rabbit is already here

Go to the Setup Checklist on page 26 and audit what you have. If hay is not unlimited and not the bulk of what the rabbit eats, fix that this week: it is the single most protective habit available to you, and it prevents most of Section 03. If your rabbit is off its food right now, do not read further. Go to page 18, then call a vet today.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 26: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 34: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 27: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 35: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 30: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 36: Equipment, Vet & Bonding Log |
| ☐ Page 31: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 37: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Rabbits are sold as a starter pet and kept like a hamster, and almost everything that goes wrong follows from that one mistake. They are not a cage animal, they are not a low-contact animal, and they are not a cheap animal once the vet is counted. This package reflects current House Rabbit Society space standards and the peer-reviewed companionship and space research on page 14, cross-checked against veterinary sources listed on page 39.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A rabbit-savvy exotic vet. This matters more here than for almost any species in this series: a general small-animal clinic can genuinely miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 03, and rabbits are fragile under anaesthesia in ways dogs and cats are not. Find one before you need one, ideally through a rabbit rescue or the House Rabbit Society, and write the number on page 27.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Oryctolagus cuniculus</i> , the European rabbit, ancestor of 300-plus breeds
Adult size	Highly variable by breed, from 2.5 lb (1.1 kg) dwarfs to 20 lb (9 kg) giants
Lifespan	7 to 10 years indoors, some past 12. Outdoor rabbits average closer to 2
Native range	Iberian Peninsula, spread by the Romans and now worldwide
Diet type	Hindgut-fermenting herbivore. Grass hay is 80 to 85%, unlimited (page 8)
Space minimum	8 sq ft (0.75 m ²) enclosure plus 24 sq ft (2.2 m ²) exercise, 5+ hours a day
The one hard rule	No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours is an emergency, not a wait-and-see (page 18)
Housing	Indoors. A bonded, neutered pair beats a single rabbit (page 15)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate. Fragile spine, so support is not optional (page 11)
Conservation status	Endangered in the wild (IUCN), despite being invasive where introduced

Cost overview

First year

\$1,000 to \$1,500 all in: \$150 to \$600 of setup, \$150 to \$500 for a spay or neuter, then food and litter. Adoption fees of \$25 to \$100 often include the surgery already.

Every year after

\$500 to \$800. Food and litter run \$60 to \$100 a month, plus two wellness exams at \$60 to \$100 each.

THE NUMBER THAT CATCHES PEOPLE OUT

A GI stasis workup alone can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits need an exotic vet whose rates are higher than a general clinic's. Keep \$500 to \$1,000 set aside separately from the routine budget. Rabbits hide illness well, and when something goes wrong it goes wrong within hours.

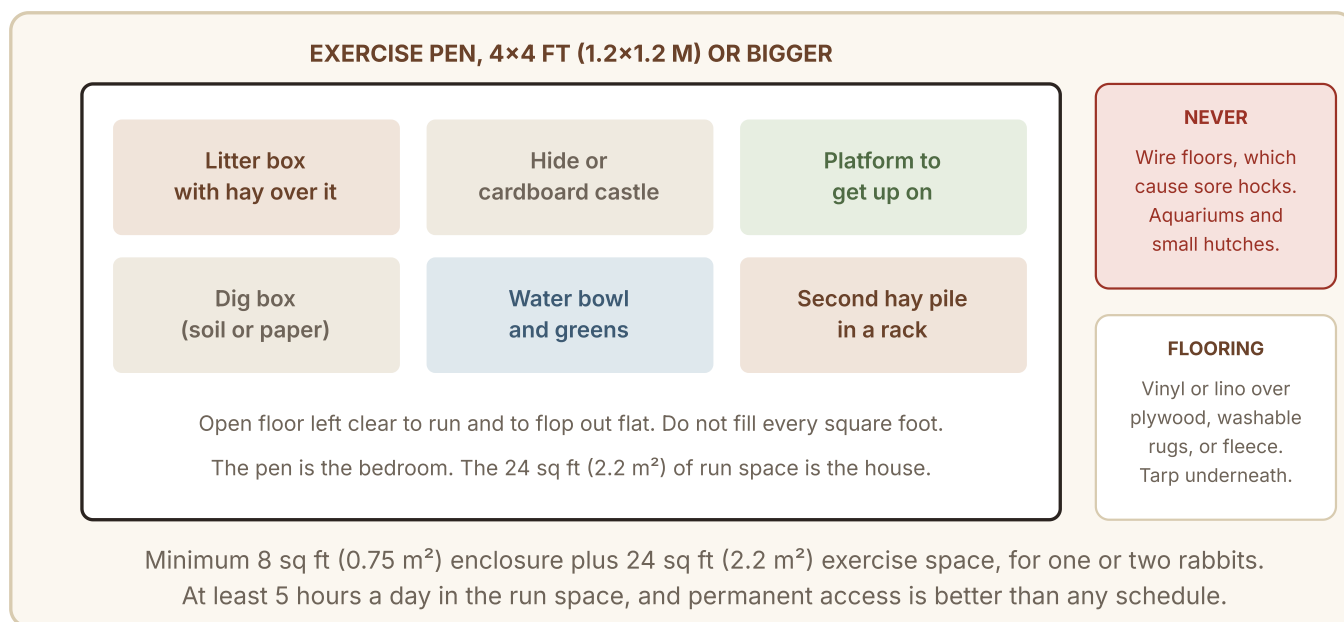
Fun facts worth knowing

- They eat some of their droppings on purpose. Cecotropes are soft pellets produced overnight and taken directly from the source, carrying B vitamins the gut bacteria made on the first pass. A rabbit that stops eating them is telling you something (page 25).
- Their teeth never stop. A rabbit's teeth grow as much as 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year, which is why the diet has to do the filing. Hay is not a bedding material with a nutritional bonus, it is the dental equipment.
- Rabbit milk is so rich that mothers nurse once, occasionally twice, a day for 2 to 10 minutes. Kits go roughly a day between feeds, which is why an unattended nest is usually normal rather than abandoned.

Housing & space

The House Rabbit Society standard is at least 8 sq ft (0.75 m²) of enclosure combined with at least 24 sq ft (2.2 m²) of exercise space for one or two rabbits, with a minimum of 5 hours a day to run in it. In practice that means a large foldable metal exercise pen, 4×4 ft (1.2×1.2 m) or bigger, and not a cage the rabbit is let out of occasionally. The wire hutch sold as a "rabbit cage" is a fraction of this and current welfare guidance considers it genuinely inadequate.

Permanent access beats scheduled access. A rabbit let out for an hour a day spends the other twenty-three confined, and the research on page 14 measured time-of-day effects for a reason: rabbits are crepuscular and want the room at dawn and dusk, not when it suits the household.



NEVER

House a rabbit in an aquarium or any solid-walled container. Ventilation is the problem: ammonia from urine builds up in still air and irritates the respiratory tract over time, which is the slow road to the snuffles on page 22.

Flooring, litter training & rabbit-proofing

Flooring

Skip wire flooring entirely. It is the direct cause of sore hocks, which is on page 23 and is miserable to treat. Vinyl or linoleum laid over plywood, washable rugs, or fleece all give better traction and are easier on the feet. Put a waterproof tarp under the whole setup: accidents are not a training failure, they are a fact of the first few months.

Litter training, which is easier than it sounds

Rabbits eliminate almost reflexively while they eat, so the trick is not teaching a new behavior, it is routing an existing one. Put the hay directly in or immediately over the litter box and most of the training does itself.

USE A BIG BOX

A large cat-style box, not the small corner trays sold for rabbits. It needs room to sit and eat at once.

RIGHT LITTER

Paper-based or compressed wood pellet. A shallow layer, with the hay on top or in a rack directly above it.

SPAY OR NEUTER

If training stalls with an intact rabbit, this is usually why. Hormonal marking overrides the habit, and the surgery resolves it (page 16).

NEVER USE THESE LITTERS

Clumping cat litter, which causes serious problems if eaten, and pine or cedar shavings, whose aromatic oils irritate the respiratory system. Both are sold in the small-pet aisle and both are wrong here.

Rabbit-proofing the room

A rabbit will chew what it can reach, and the chewing is not naughtiness, it is a continuously growing set of teeth doing what they do. Proof the space rather than fighting the instinct.

- ☐ Every accessible cable in split-loom tubing or lifted out of reach. This is the one that can kill
- ☐ Carpet edges and corners covered, since these are the classic digging targets
- ☐ Houseplants moved up and out. Assume anything reachable will be tasted
- ☐ Gaps behind and under furniture blocked, or you will spend an evening on your stomach with a torch
- ☐ Baseboards and furniture legs shielded with cardboard, plastic guards, or a strategically placed dig box
- ☐ Anything toxic, cleaning products included, behind a door rather than on a low shelf

GIVE THE BEHAVIOR SOMEWHERE TO GO

Proofing alone moves the problem. Pair every block with an outlet: a dig box by the carpet corner they favor, willow or cardboard where they chewed the skirting. A rabbit with nowhere to dig picks somewhere, and not the somewhere you would choose.

Indoors, outdoors & temperature

This is a lifespan decision, not a preference, and the gap is larger than almost any other choice in this book.

INDOORS

7 to 10 years, and some past 12. You see the rabbit daily and closely, which is how illness gets caught in the hours that matter.

OUTDOORS

About 2 years on average. Predators, weather, and health problems that go unnoticed without daily close contact.

The second half is what people underestimate. A rabbit outdoors is not just exposed to foxes and heat, it is out of sight. The window between a rabbit going off its food and being in genuine danger is measured in hours (page 18), and nobody notices it from indoors.

Temperature

Rabbits are far better at cold than at heat: a dense coat, no sweat glands, and heat shed mainly through the ears.

RANGE	WHAT IT MEANS
61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C)	Merck's optimal rabbit environment. A normal indoor room, and no intervention needed
Above 77°F (25°C)	Start actively cooling, ahead of the line: airflow, a frozen water bottle wrapped in a towel to lie against, a ceramic tile in the shade
Above 80°F (27°C)	The line. VCA calls it critical to keep a rabbit at or below this. Move to the coolest room and do not wait to see how it copes
Below 50°F (10°C)	Merck notes rabbits tolerate subzero outdoor temperatures given proper shelter, so an acclimated rabbit with deep bedding and a windbreak copes. Indoors, drafts and damp bedding cause far more cold-related illness than a steadily cool room. See the lifespan figures above first

Heatstroke signs arrive in an order: rapid shallow breathing, then drooling or salivating, then weakness and a rabbit lying stretched flat and unwilling to move, with red or very hot ears and a wet nose throughout. Cool the ears with a damp cloth, move the rabbit somewhere cooler, and call the vet. Do not submerge a rabbit in cold water: the shock is its own emergency.

IF A RABBIT MUST LIVE OUTSIDE

A shed or large predator-proof structure rather than a hutch, with a permanently attached run, deep bedding, shade at every hour, and daily hands-on checks including the rear end for flystrike (page 22). Even then, bring it in for heat waves, cold snaps and any illness, and expect to catch problems later than indoors.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Diet: hay first

If you take one thing from this package, take this page. Unlimited grass hay prevents most of Section 03.

Grass hay should be 80 to 85% of what an adult rabbit eats, available 24 hours a day, never rationed. Timothy, orchard, or meadow hay all work. It is doing two jobs at once, and both of them are the jobs that kill rabbits when they are not done.

JOB ONE: THE GUT

Rabbits are hindgut fermenters and the gut has to keep moving. Long-strand fiber is what moves it. Low fiber is the biggest risk factor for GI stasis (page 18).

JOB TWO: THE TEETH

Rabbit teeth grow 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year. The side-to-side grinding of long hay is what wears them down. Pellets are chewed differently and do not do this (page 21).

Which hay

HAY	WHO	NOTES
Timothy	ADULTS	The default. First cut is coarser and better for teeth, second cut softer and more palatable
Orchard grass	ADULTS	Softer and sweeter than timothy. A good option if a rabbit refuses timothy, or if you are allergic to it yourself
Meadow hay	ADULTS	Mixed grasses, more varied texture, often the most interesting to forage through
Oat hay	MIX IN	Offer alongside a grass hay rather than instead of it. Some rabbits eat only the seed heads and leave the stalks
Alfalfa	UNDER 6 MONTHS	A legume, not a grass. Right for kits, juveniles, pregnant or nursing does, and underweight seniors. Too rich for a healthy adult: the calcium and calories drive obesity and bladder sludge

Making hay take time

Hay is also the cheapest enrichment here, and presentation matters. Stuff it into cardboard tubes, hang it in bundles, scatter greens through it, and keep a rack over the litter box so eating and toileting happen in the same corner, which is where the rabbit wants them anyway.

BUYING AND STORING IT

Buy in bulk from a feed store rather than small pet-shop bags: cheaper per pound and fresher. Store it dry and airy, never sealed in plastic, which traps moisture and grows mold. Good hay smells sweet, is green rather than yellow-brown, and is not dusty.

A RABBIT NOT EATING HAY IS A PROBLEM, NOT A PREFERENCE

The two usual reasons are that pellets or treats are filling it up, in which case cut those back, or that eating hurts, which means dental disease and a vet visit (page 21). Both need acting on. A rabbit that eats everything but hay is on a trajectory toward the emergency on page 18.

Greens, pellets & the never-feed list

Everything that is not hay, in order of how much of it there should be.

Portions for an adult

FOOD	HOW MUCH	NOTES
Grass hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet	Never measured, never empty (page 8)
Leafy greens	1 cup per 2 lb (1 kg) daily	At least 3 varieties a day. Introduce anything new one item at a time and watch for soft stool
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily	Plain, high-fiber, timothy-based. Measured, never free-fed. Sources vary, so start low
Fruit and treats	1 to 2 tbsp, once or twice a week	Not daily, and not carrots as a staple
Water	Always available	Bowl or bottle, but most rabbits drink more readily from a heavy ceramic bowl

Greens and treats by tier

Romaine, cilantro, parsley, basil, arugula, bok choy, carrot tops, mint	DAILY	Rotate three a day. Fresh, washed, not cold from the fridge
Bell pepper, cucumber, carrot	LIMITED	More sugar and starch than their reputation. Small pieces only
Apple, banana, strawberry, blueberry	TREAT	1 to 2 tbsp total, once or twice a week. No apple seeds
Iceberg lettuce	SKIP IT	Not toxic, but nearly empty nutritionally and upsetting in quantity. No reason to use it
Muesli-style mixes with seeds, nuts, or colored pieces	NEVER	Rabbits eat the sweet bits and leave the fiber. Linked to obesity and dental disease
Avocado	NEVER	Causes respiratory distress and fatal heart failure
Chocolate	NEVER	Toxic, as it is to most pets
Onion, garlic, chives	NEVER	Cause hemolytic anemia
Rhubarb	NEVER	High oxalic acid, linked to kidney damage. The leaves especially
Bread, crackers, cereal, yogurt drops	NEVER	Yogurt drops are sold as rabbit treats and are explicitly inappropriate
Grass clippings from a mower	NEVER	Ferment fast. Hand-picked grass from an untreated lawn is fine, mower cuttings are not

Feeding by life stage

The diet changes twice: once off alfalfa, and once into old age.

STAGE	FEEDING
Nursing kits birth to about 7 weeks	Mother's milk, and she nurses just once, occasionally twice, a day for 2 to 10 minutes. Rabbit milk is unusually rich, so kits go roughly a day between feeds. A nest left alone is normal, not abandoned. Weaned by around 8 weeks
Transition 3 to 7 weeks	Alfalfa hay and alfalfa-based pellets introduced free-choice alongside nursing. New greens usually start around 12 weeks, in small amounts
Juvenile 7 weeks to 7 months	Unlimited alfalfa hay and alfalfa-based pellets: the extra calories and calcium support growth. Vegetables added gradually from about 3 months, one new item at a time
Changeover roughly 4 to 6 months	Alfalfa phased out for grass hays, and pellet portions reduced gradually over several weeks as unlimited grass hay takes over as the base of the diet. Do this slowly
Adult 7 months to about 5 years	Unlimited grass hay at 80 to 85% of the diet. Measured pellets, 1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily. Greens at about 1 cup per 2 lb (1 kg), at least 3 varieties. Treats capped at 1 to 2 tbsp once or twice a week
Senior 6 years and up	Unlimited grass hay continues. Alfalfa may come back if the rabbit is losing weight, treats are allowed more freely, and feeding becomes individual and vet-guided rather than by the table

What changes with age, beyond the food

- Weigh a senior rabbit monthly. Weight loss is the earliest signal of dental disease, kidney trouble, and most of Section 03.
- Watch for a rabbit that stops eating its cecotropes or gets messy at the rear: arthritis or obesity can stop it reaching (page 25).
- Move to twice-yearly vet exams if you were not already there, and expect the vet to want to see the back teeth.
- Soften the setup: lower platforms, a ramp instead of a hop, thicker bedding for sore hocks.

CHANGE FOOD SLOWLY, ALWAYS

There is no gut-loading or calcium dusting here, that is a reptile practice. The rabbit equivalent of getting it wrong is changing food too fast. A sudden switch of hay, pellets, or vegetables disrupts the cecal bacteria and produces soft stool or a stasis episode. Transition over a week or two.

THE ONE FIGURE TO HOLD ON TO

Sources put the alarm point for a rabbit not eating anywhere from 3 to 12 hours, and agree that fasting beyond about 24 hours risks fatty liver disease. Do not wait through a full day hoping it resolves. Same-day vet contact is the safe default the moment a rabbit skips a meal or stops producing normal droppings, at any age (page 18).

Handling: picking a rabbit up

Rabbits are more fragile than almost any first-time owner expects, and getting this wrong breaks bones.

WHY SUPPORT IS THE WHOLE THING

A rabbit that struggles against an unsupported hold can fracture its own lumbar spine. Its hind legs are powerful enough to do that, and without full body support that power works in exactly the wrong direction. This is not a handling preference. It is the single most important physical thing to get right with this species.

Picking one up

1. One hand on the chest just behind the front legs, the other under the hindquarters. Both at once, never one then the other.
2. Lift with both regions supported and bring the rabbit straight in against your body, not out at arm's length.
3. Stay low to the ground for the whole session, so a struggle ends in a short drop rather than a long one.
4. If it struggles, lower it back down immediately in one smooth motion, in a straight line. Do not try to keep your grip.

The "football hold" is worth learning: the rabbit's head tucked into the crook of your elbow, body along your forearm. Vets use it because it is secure and low-stress at once.

NEVER

Lift a rabbit by the ears, ever. Never rely on the scruff alone to carry its weight: even where a grip at the neck is used to steady an animal, the body has to be supported underneath.

Building trust & reading a rabbit

Most rabbits never learn to love being picked up. A relationship built on the floor works better anyway.

Skip trancing

You will see advice about flipping a rabbit onto its back to calm it, sometimes called trancing. Don't. Research measuring rabbits in that position found significant increases in respiration, heart rate, and stress hormones. The stillness is a fear response the animal cannot escape, and it looks calm to the untrained eye, which is why the myth lasted.

Building trust instead

- Most rabbits are calmest with all four feet down, and many never learn to enjoy being picked up even once they trust you. That is normal.
- Sit or lie down at the rabbit's level and wait. Let it come to you rather than reaching in.
- Hand-feed a green or a piece of herb at floor level. Repetition does the work.
- Aim for a rabbit relaxed around you rather than one that tolerates being carried. Pick-ups can stay rare.

Stress signals to stop on

Thumping a hind foot · a tense, rigid body · wide eyes · fast, shallow breathing · teeth grinding, which is a pain signal here and not the soft contented tooth-purring · freezing in place · bolting or kicking.

Those are in-the-moment signals. When freezing or constant hiding becomes the baseline rather than a reaction to handling, that is a longer-running welfare problem, and the answer is on pages 5, 14 and 15, 13 and 14 rather than in your technique.

Common mistakes

Almost every one of these is a decision made at the pet shop, before the rabbit came home.

MISTAKE	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENS
Buying the cage sold as a rabbit cage	It is a fraction of the current standard. Confinement shows up as awake inactivity and reduced behavioral diversity, which owners read as a calm rabbit (page 14)
Pellets as the main food	Obesity, dental disease, and a gut that has lost its fiber. This is the root of most of Section 03
Treating hay as bedding	Hay is the diet and the dental equipment. Bedding is a separate purchase
Muesli-style food with seeds and colored bits	The rabbit eats the sweet pieces and leaves the fiber, which is the worst of both worlds
Keeping one rabbit and buying toys instead	The research measured that gap and toys were not what closed it. A companion was (page 15)
Not spaying or neutering	Up to 80% of unspayed does aged 5 and over develop uterine cancer, plus marking, aggression, and failed litter training (page 16)
Wire flooring	Sore hocks, which are slow to heal and easy to prevent (page 23)
Waiting overnight on a rabbit that stopped eating	The most dangerous mistake in this book. That night is often the difference between a full recovery and a death (page 18)
Using a general small-animal vet	Rabbit physiology, anaesthesia, and drug tolerances differ enough that a non-specialist can miss or mishandle the conditions in Section 03
Trancing a rabbit to calm it	Measured heart rate and stress hormones say it is fear, not relaxation (page 12)
Scheduling exercise for the household's convenience	Rabbits are crepuscular. An hour at 8pm is not the hour they wanted

THE PATTERN UNDER ALL OF THEM

A rabbit is not a small, low-input pet that lives in a box. It is a social, crepuscular grazer with a gut that fails fast and teeth that never stop growing. Every mistake above comes from the first description. Almost every fix comes from taking the second one seriously.

Enrichment: what the research says

The enrichment aisle is full of things to put in a hutch. The evidence points somewhere much less commercial.

Companionship

A study of social housing conditions in privately owned rabbits found that solitary rabbits expressed **less behavioral diversity** and **more awake inactivity** than socially housed ones. Socially housed rabbits were more active. The same work found that a larger age difference between paired rabbits was associated with a lower friendship index, which is a practical steer when choosing a companion.

Space, measured in a stress hormone

A study of pair-housed pet rabbits found that **run access, hutch size, and time of day** all affected welfare-relevant behavior and fecal corticosterone. Space is not a nicety here. It registers in a stress hormone metabolite, and the time-of-day finding is why permanent access beats a scheduled hour.

Structure

In group-housed rabbits, an elevated platform let animals move up and down, rest more comfortably, and **increase exploratory behavior**. Somewhere to get on top of, and somewhere to get underneath, is worth building in from the start.

AWAKE INACTIVITY

This is the uncomfortable one to learn about, because a still rabbit reads as a contented rabbit from the sofa. The measure exists precisely because those two states look identical from across a room. A rabbit sitting motionless and awake for long stretches in a small space is displaying the pattern the research associates with poorer welfare, not relaxing.

Priority order

1. A neutered, bonded companion, close in age
2. Permanent run access or a rabbit-proofed room
3. Unlimited hay, presented so it takes time to eat
4. A dig box
5. Platforms to get on and cover to get under
6. Chewing and shredding material: bamboo sticks, untreated willow, plain cardboard
7. Novel objects, last, and the cheap part

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't keep a rabbit alone and expect toys to close the gap: the research measured that gap and toys were not what changed it. Don't treat a hutch as housing. Don't schedule exercise around the household when the animal is crepuscular. Don't feed a muesli mix instead of hay. Don't pair rabbits without neutering both first. And don't treat digging as a behavior problem, because it is a burrowing animal doing what burrowing animals do.

Bonding & companionship

The highest-value thing you can do for a rabbit, and the one that takes the longest to do properly.

A neutered, bonded pair does things a single rabbit does not: mutual grooming, resting in contact, and simply more behavior of every kind. A single rabbit with an attentive owner is a compromise rather than an equivalent, and this is the finding the research most directly supports (page 14).

Choosing a companion

- Neuter both first, and wait the vet's recommended interval before introducing. Hormones sabotage bonds that would otherwise work.
- Closer in age is better: the friendship index dropped as the age gap widened.
- Neutered male with spayed female is the pairing that works most often, though same-sex pairs are common and fine.
- Many rescues run "bunny dating," where your rabbit meets candidates on neutral ground and picks. Use it if it exists near you.
- Size and breed matter far less than temperament. A calm giant and a calm dwarf will usually do better than two pushy rabbits of matched size.

How bonding actually goes

STAGE	WHAT YOU DO
Side by side	Separate pens next to each other, swapped daily so each rabbit lives in the other's scent. Days to weeks
First meeting	Neutral territory neither rabbit has claimed, cleared of anything to guard. Short, supervised, with a towel and a dustpan on hand to separate safely rather than with your hands
Stress bonding	A mildly novel space or a car ride makes the rabbits allies against a shared oddity. Effective for some pairs, unnecessary for others
Building up	Sessions lengthen as long as they end well. Grooming, resting in contact, and eating side by side are the signs it is working
Full-time	Only after they have slept touching through several long supervised sessions. Give them a cleaned, rearranged space so neither owns it

WHAT IS NORMAL AND WHAT IS NOT

Chasing, mounting, and light nipping are normal early negotiation, and interrupting every one of them prevents the pair from settling a hierarchy. Fur pulled out in clumps, a rabbit cornered and unable to escape, or any biting that draws blood means separate immediately and go back a stage. Never leave a new pair alone together, and never break up a fight with bare hands.

IT TAKES WEEKS

Going too fast is how bonding fails. Weeks is normal, months happens. Keep a bonded pair together for vet visits too: separating them even for a day can break a bond, so ask the vet to see both in the same carrier.

Spay, neuter & why it isn't optional

THE NUMBER THIS PAGE EXISTS FOR

Up to **80% of unspayed does aged 5 and older develop uterine cancer**, with risk climbing from around age two. That is one of the highest lifetime cancer risks documented in any commonly kept pet, which is why rabbit-savvy vets treat spaying as close to routine rather than as an elective extra.

What it changes

Females

- Removes the uterine cancer risk almost entirely when done young
- Ends false pregnancies, nest-building, and the territorial aggression that comes with them
- Makes litter training work, since hormonal marking stops

Males

- Stops urine spraying, which is the behavior most owners cannot live with
- Reduces mounting, circling, and territorial aggression
- Makes bonding possible at all: an intact rabbit is very hard to pair (page 15)

Timing and cost

When	Males from around 4 months, females from 5 to 6, though your vet goes by size rather than the calendar. Earlier is better for the cancer risk, but not before the rabbit is grown enough for safe anaesthesia
Neuter	Typically \$200 to \$300
Spay	More, since it is more invasive. Budget \$150 to \$500 or more overall, with exotic and metro clinics at the higher end
Low-cost programs	Nonprofit clinics sometimes bring it down to around \$139 to \$150. Rabbit rescues usually know which ones are near you
Adoption	Fees of \$25 to \$100 frequently include the surgery and an initial vet check already. For many people, adopting an altered rabbit is the cheapest route overall, not the pet store

Choosing who does it

Ask directly how many rabbit spays or neuters the practice does in a year, and what their fasting policy is. The answer you want is Merck's: fasting for longer than three hours is neither required nor recommended, because rabbits cannot vomit and their stomachs are never empty anyway. A short one to two hour fast is normal, and its purpose is clearing the mouth, not settling the stomach. A clinic that says withhold food overnight, the way it would for a dog, does not do many rabbits.

RECOVERY

Hay, greens and water go in front of a rabbit as soon as possible after surgery, and eating again is the number that matters. Merck's bar is **2 to 3 hours**: a rabbit that has not eaten by then needs its pain relief reviewed, not more waiting. Bring hay and a favorite green to the clinic, and ask what pain relief goes home with you.

Health red flags & the rabbit-savvy vet

BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE ON THIS LIST

Rabbits need a rabbit-savvy exotic vet, not a standard small-animal clinic. This is not snobbery about credentials. Rabbit physiology, anaesthetic protocols, and drug tolerances differ enough that a vet unfamiliar with the species can genuinely miss or mishandle everything in this section. Find one before you need one, ideally through a rabbit rescue or the House Rabbit Society, and write the number on page 27 today.

Go to a vet today

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT POINTS AT
No food and no droppings for 8 to 12 hours	GI stasis. Same-day, not overnight (page 18)
Droppings small, misshapen, or strung together with fur	Early stasis, hours before it becomes obvious (page 18)
Hunched posture with the belly pulled in, audible tooth grinding	Abdominal pain. Grinding here is pain, not contentment
A bloated or tense abdomen	Gas or blockage. This one hurts and escalates fast
Visible fly eggs or maggots anywhere in the fur	Flystrike. Can kill within 24 to 48 hours (page 22)
Drooling, dropping food while eating, weight loss	Dental disease (page 21)
Eye or nasal discharge, sneezing, crusted front paws	Snuffles, usually <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> (page 22)
Head tilt, loss of balance, rolling	<i>E. cuniculi</i> or an inner ear infection (page 23)
Open-mouth breathing	Rabbits are obligate nose breathers. This is an emergency at any hour
Straining to urinate, or thick, gritty urine	Bladder sludge or stones (page 23)
Sudden lethargy, hiding, or unwillingness to move	Rabbits hide illness. By the time it shows, it is usually well established

What to have ready when you call

- When the rabbit last ate, and what
- When you last saw normal droppings, and what they look like now
- Current weight, and the trend from the log on page 35
- Whether the rabbit is spayed or neutered, and when
- Anything that changed recently: food, housing, a new pet, a move
- Vaccination status, and any medication given

GI stasis: recognizing it

Ask a rabbit vet what kills more pet rabbits than anything else and this is the answer. Not an injury, not an exotic disease. The gut slowing down.

What it actually is

Rabbits are hindgut fermenters. The digestive system relies on continuous movement to process high-fiber food and to produce two kinds of droppings, including the nutrient-rich cecotropes the rabbit re-ingests directly (page 25). When gut motility slows or stops, gas builds up, painful bloating follows, and the balance of gut bacteria shifts dangerously. Untreated, that cascade becomes life-threatening quickly.

Why rabbits specifically

Most pets can comfortably skip a meal. A rabbit's gut needs near-constant input to keep moving, and going without food for even half a day can be enough to slow motility in a rabbit that is already stressed or unwell. That is the opposite of how most mammals work, and it is why a rabbit cannot tough out an off day the way a cat or dog can.

Triggers

TRIGGER	WHY IT MATTERS
Low-fiber diet	Insufficient hay slows motility over time. The single biggest risk factor, and the one entirely in your control
Dental pain	Makes eating uncomfortable, and reduced intake alone is enough to start the cascade
Stress	A loud environment, a new pet, a move, or a vet visit can be enough on its own
Dehydration	Reduces gut lubrication and motility directly
Pain from any other cause	A rabbit in pain from anything often stops eating, which starts the same cascade
A heavy molt	Swallowed fur plus dehydrated gut contents can form a mass that is hard to pass (page 24)
Some medications	A few drugs used for other conditions slow gut motility as a side effect. Ask when anything new is prescribed

GI stasis: warning signs

The signs arrive in an order, and the first one you can see without touching the rabbit.

Early warning signs, in the order they usually appear

1. **Reduced or absent fecal output.** The earliest and most reliable sign, and the reason a daily glance at the litter box is worth more than any other habit in this book.
2. **Smaller, oddly shaped, or fur-strung droppings** in the hours before output stops entirely.
3. **Reduced appetite**, picking at food without refusing it outright.
4. **Hunched posture** with the belly pulled in, the classic sign of abdominal pain.
5. **Teeth grinding (bruxism)** at a harsh, audible pitch. This is distinct from the soft tooth-purring a relaxed rabbit does, and once you have heard both you will not confuse them.

KNOW YOUR OUT-OF-HOURS OPTION NOW

Most rabbit vets are not open at 2am, and most emergency clinics do not see rabbits. Find out tonight which clinic near you will take a rabbit out of hours, how far it is, and what it costs. Write it on page 27. Working that out during the emergency costs the hours the emergency is made of.

WHY WAIT AND SEE IS DANGEROUS HERE

With most illnesses, a day of monitoring at home is reasonable. With GI stasis, that same day is often the difference between a rabbit that recovers fully and one that does not. A rabbit that has produced no droppings in 8 to 12 hours, or has stopped eating entirely, needs a **same-day** visit to a rabbit-savvy or exotic vet. Not tomorrow morning.

GI stasis: treatment & prevention

What treatment looks like

Veterinary treatment typically means subcutaneous fluids, pain management, and motility medication, alongside identifying and treating whatever triggered the episode in the first place. That last part matters: a rabbit having a stasis episode usually needs a full workup rather than symptomatic treatment alone, because stasis is very often the visible end of something else, most commonly dental pain.

Syringe-feeding a critical care formula is often part of recovery, but it should be guided by a vet rather than attempted blind. Force-feeding a rabbit with a genuine blockage rather than a slowdown can make things worse, and the two look similar from the outside.

THE NUMBER WORTH HOLDING ON TO

Roughly **70% of rabbits recover with prompt veterinary treatment**. Delayed cases can need days of hospitalization and do considerably worse. Early intervention is not a nicety here, it is most of the outcome.

While you are getting to the vet

Do

- Call first, and say the words "not eating, no droppings." That phrasing gets a rabbit seen faster than "seems a bit off."
- Offer water, and offer the most tempting fresh greens you have. Wet greens add fluid too.
- Keep the rabbit warm, quiet, and with its bonded partner if it has one.
- Bring a sample of any droppings produced, and note the time of the last normal one.

Don't

- Don't syringe-feed without veterinary direction.
- Don't give simethicone, pineapple juice, or any home remedy in place of the appointment. Some of it is harmless, none of it is treatment.
- Don't massage a hard, tense abdomen. If there is a blockage, this hurts and can do damage.
- Don't wait for the morning to see if it passes.

Prevention, which is most of the answer

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Unlimited grass hay at 80% or more of the diet. The single most protective habit available to any rabbit owner (page 8) | ☐ A daily glance at the litter box. Just a glance, to see that output looks normal in size and quantity |
| ☐ Fresh water always available, and greens that carry moisture with them | ☐ Brushing through heavy molts, so less fur is swallowed (page 24) |
| ☐ Diet changes made gradually over a week or two, never overnight | ☐ Twice-yearly dental checks, since dental pain is the most common hidden trigger |

Dental disease

The most common hidden cause of everything else in this section, and the one that develops silently.

Cause	Rabbit teeth grow continuously, as much as 4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm) a year, and they are worn down by the side-to-side grinding of long-strand fiber. A diet short on hay lets them overgrow. Molar spurs form on the outside edges and cut the tongue or cheek; incisors can grow past each other and stop meeting at all. Genetics play a part too, and some breeds, particularly flat-faced dwarfs and lops, are predisposed regardless of diet
Signs	Drizzling, or a permanently damp chin and dewlap. Dropping food while trying to eat, or taking a piece and putting it down again. A preference for soft food over hay. Weight loss. Pawing at the mouth. Watery eyes, because the roots of overgrown upper teeth press on the tear ducts. Reduced or absent cecotrope eating, since bending down to take them hurts
Response	A vet exam, which for the back teeth means sedation and a proper look: molar spurs are not visible from the front and a torch through the incisors does not find them. Treatment is usually a sedated burr or trim. Overgrown incisors may need repeat trims, and in severe cases extraction, after which rabbits do surprisingly well on a modified diet
Recovery	Pain relief and a return to eating within a day or two of the trim. Recurrence is common, so many rabbits settle into a schedule of trims every few months. The prevention is unchanged: unlimited hay, from day one and for life

WHY THIS PAGE SITS BEFORE THE OTHERS

Dental pain is the most common hidden trigger for GI stasis. A rabbit whose mouth hurts eats less, and a rabbit that eats less has a gut that slows. If your rabbit has had a stasis episode with no obvious cause, the back teeth are the first place to look, which is why a full workup matters more than treating the stasis alone (page 20).

What you can check at home

- Lift the lips and look at the incisors weekly. They should meet cleanly, top slightly overlapping bottom, with no spiralling or splaying.
- Run a finger gently along the jawline. Lumps or bumps along the bone can mean root overgrowth or an abscess.
- Watch the rabbit eat a piece of hay. It should take it and grind steadily, not pick it up and drop it.
- Weigh weekly, and log it on page 35. Weight loss usually shows before anything visible does.

NEVER TRIM A RABBIT'S TEETH YOURSELF

Nail clippers on incisors shatter and split the tooth down its length, which causes abscesses and enormous pain. This is a sedated veterinary procedure with a dental burr. There is no home version of it.

Flystrike & snuffles

Flystrike (myiasis)

Cause	Flies lay eggs on soiled or damp fur, most often around the rear. The maggots hatch within hours and begin eating into the skin. The underlying reason is almost always something else: obesity or arthritis stopping a rabbit from cleaning itself, dental pain stopping it eating cecotropes, soft stool from a diet problem, or a wet, dirty enclosure
Signs	Visible eggs like small grains of rice in the fur, or maggots. A patch of damp, matted, or smelling fur. Sudden lethargy or a rabbit sitting still and unwilling to move. It can go from eggs to a life-threatening emergency within 24 to 48 hours
Response	Emergency vet, immediately, at any hour. On the way, pick off what maggots you can see with tweezers, but do not soak or drown the rabbit: wetting the fur drives maggots deeper and a chilled rabbit in shock is a second emergency. This is not a wait-until-morning condition
Prevention	Check the rear end daily in warm weather, twice daily for an outdoor rabbit. Keep the enclosure dry and cleaned. Fix the underlying cause: a rabbit with a permanently mucky bottom has a diet, dental, or mobility problem that needs solving, not just cleaning

Snuffles (upper respiratory infection)

Cause	Most often <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> , though other bacteria do the same job. Frequently opportunistic: poor ventilation, ammonia buildup from a solid-walled enclosure, dusty bedding, or stress lets an organism the rabbit was already carrying take hold
Signs	Eye or nasal discharge, sneezing, and the giveaway that owners miss: crusty, matted fur on the insides of the front paws, from a rabbit wiping its own nose repeatedly. Later, noisy breathing, head tilt if it reaches the inner ear, or abscesses
Response	Vet, promptly rather than same-day-urgent unless breathing is affected. Treatment is usually a long antibiotic course, often weeks, chosen on a culture rather than a guess. Ask for the culture: rabbit-safe antibiotics are a narrow list and the wrong one can cause a fatal gut reaction on its own
Recovery	Often good, but chronic carriers are common and flare-ups recur under stress. Fix the ventilation and the bedding dust alongside the antibiotics, or you are treating the same infection again in three months

OPEN-MOUTH BREATHING IS ALWAYS AN EMERGENCY

Rabbits are obligate nose breathers. A rabbit breathing through its mouth has an airway that is genuinely obstructed or a respiratory system in real trouble, and it is a same-hour call whatever else is going on.

E. cuniculi, sore hocks, bladder sludge & RHDV2

Encephalitozoon cuniculi

A microsporidian parasite carried by a large share of pet rabbits, often with no signs at all. When it becomes active it affects the brain, kidneys, or eyes. The classic presentation is a **head tilt**, sometimes with rolling or loss of balance, and it also contributes to recurrent GI stasis episodes and to cataracts. Treatment is a course of fenbendazole plus supportive care, and the earlier it starts the better the outcome. A head tilt is not always *E. cuniculi*: an inner ear infection looks the same from outside, and telling them apart is the vet's job.

Sore hocks (pododermatitis)

Pressure sores on the underside of the hind feet, which rabbits lack the thick footpads to protect. Caused by wire flooring, hard or abrasive surfaces, inadequate bedding, damp, obesity, or simply too little movement. Starts as fur loss and reddened skin, progresses to open ulcers and, untreated, to bone infection. Prevention is soft, dry, non-abrasive flooring and a rabbit at a healthy weight. Once it is open it needs veterinary treatment and it is slow to heal, so catching the bald patch stage is worth the weekly look.

Bladder sludge and stones

Rabbits absorb dietary calcium unusually inefficiently and excrete the surplus through the kidneys, so their urine is naturally chalky. When it thickens into a gritty sludge or forms stones, it causes straining, urine scald on the rear, blood in the urine, and pain. The drivers are a diet too high in calcium (alfalfa fed to an adult, or calcium-rich greens in excess), too little water, and too little exercise. Prevention is a grass-hay diet, water always available and made appealing, and enough room to move.

RHDV2

Rabbit Haemorrhagic Disease Virus type 2. Highly contagious, frequently fatal, and often kills with no warning signs at all. It survives on surfaces, clothing, shoes, and hay, so indoor-only rabbits are not automatically safe. **Annual vaccination is recommended in the US** and is genuinely worth discussing with your vet rather than treating as an optional extra. In the UK and much of Europe a combined vaccine also covers myxomatosis and RHDV1. Ask your vet what is standard where you live rather than assuming this package's list is complete for your region.

THE PATTERN IN THIS SECTION

Three of these four are prevented by things already covered: grass hay instead of alfalfa, soft dry flooring, room to move, and water that gets drunk. The fourth is prevented by a vaccine. Very little on this page is treated better than it is avoided, which is the argument for the twice-yearly exam on page 17.

Grooming, nails & molting

Rabbits groom themselves thoroughly and cannot vomit, which is the whole reason this page exists.

Molting

Rabbits molt roughly every three months, and Merck's point is that the pattern is unpredictable: one molt can be light and the next heavy. A heavy molt comes out in tufts, in a line down the body, or leaves bald patches that regrow within days. It is normal. The risk is the fur the rabbit swallows while grooming: a cat coughs up a hairball, and a rabbit cannot. A rabbit normally carries some hair in its stomach and passes it, so fur is rarely the cause of a stasis episode on its own. What it does is compound a gut that has already slowed for some other reason, which is why a heavy molt is a fortnight to watch closely rather than a shedding nuisance (page 18).

- ☐ Brush daily through a heavy molt, and at least twice weekly otherwise. Long-haired breeds need daily grooming year-round without exception
- ☐ A rubber grooming mitt or a fine comb. Slicker brushes catch the skin, which is thin and tears easily
- ☐ Pluck loose tufts out gently by hand as they lift. This gets more fur out than brushing alone
- ☐ Push hay and water hard through a molt. Fiber and fluid are what move swallowed fur through

Nails

Trim every 6 to 8 weeks, which is Lafeber's interval for both rabbits and guinea pigs. Overgrown nails change how a rabbit stands, which loads the hocks wrongly and contributes to the sores on page 23, and they catch and tear. On a pale nail the pink quick shows through. On a dark one, hold a torch *behind* the nail and the quick becomes visible against the light, which beats guessing; failing that, take a very small amount at a time and stop when the cut surface changes texture. Keep styptic powder or cornflour out and open before you start, for the one you will eventually catch. Two people is easier than one: one holds and supports the rabbit properly, the other trims.

Bathing, scent glands, and the rest

- **Never full-bath a rabbit.** Wet fur is slow to dry and chills them fast, and the Rabbit Welfare Association warns that a rabbit panicking in water can fracture its spine or a limb thrashing to get out. Spot-clean with a damp cloth instead, and dry thoroughly.
- A mucky rear needs the cause fixed, not just cleaning. See flystrike on page 22.
- The scent glands either side of the genitals collect a dark, strong-smelling wax. Clean them every 6 to 8 weeks, in the same session as the nails. Have a rabbit-savvy vet or groomer show you once first: the area is sensitive and easy to irritate with the wrong method.
- Check ears for wax buildup, especially in lops, whose ear canals drain poorly.

MAKE GROOMING THE HEALTH CHECK

Every session is a chance to run your hands over the whole rabbit: lumps, scabs, sore hocks, a damp chin, a matted rear, weight change. Doing both at once means the check actually happens.

Reading droppings & cecotropes

The litter box is the best diagnostic instrument you own, and checking it takes five seconds a day.

Rabbits make two kinds

FECAL PELLETS

Round, dry, uniform, straw-colored to dark brown, and roughly pea-sized in an average rabbit. Made of indigestible fiber. These are what you see in the litter box, in large quantities, all day.

CECOTROPES

Soft, dark, shiny, clustered like a tiny blackberry, and strong-smelling. Produced mostly overnight and eaten directly from the source. You should rarely see one, because the rabbit takes it.

Cecotropes are not an accident and not a sign of anything wrong. They carry B vitamins and protein that the cecal bacteria produced but that were not absorbed on the first pass, and eating them is a genuine part of rabbit digestion. Do not stop the rabbit doing it, and do not clean them away before it can.

What the litter box is telling you

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS
Plenty of round, even, pea-sized pellets	Normal. This is what a well-hayed rabbit produces, in quantity
Fewer pellets than yesterday	The earliest sign of stasis. Check food intake now, don't wait for the count to reach zero (page 18)
Small, hard, dark, misshapen pellets	Dehydration or slowing motility. Push water and greens, and watch closely for the next few hours
Pellets strung together with fur	Molt-related. Brush daily and increase hay and water (page 24)
No pellets at all for 8 to 12 hours	Same-day vet. This is the line (page 18)
Soft, unformed, or pudding-like stool	True diarrhea is rare in adults and is an emergency, particularly in a young rabbit. Vet today
Squashed cecotropes stuck to the fur or the floor	Not diarrhea. Usually too many pellets or too much sugar in the diet, so the rabbit produces more than it wants. Cut pellets and treats first, then check for obesity or arthritis stopping it reaching
Pellets much larger than usual after an illness	Often a good sign: the gut is moving again and clearing what backed up
Very pale, very small, or very dusty pellets	Too little fiber. Look hard at how much hay is actually being eaten rather than how much is available
Blood in or on the droppings	Vet today. Blood from the rear can also be urinary, which is page 23

THE FIVE-SECOND HABIT

Look in the litter box every time you pass it, and once properly each morning. You are not counting, you are looking for a change in quantity or shape. Almost every owner who caught stasis early caught it here, and almost every owner who caught it late says the same thing about the day before.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Exercise pen, 4×4 ft (1.2×1.2 m) or bigger, plus run space
- ☐ Solid, non-slip flooring and a waterproof tarp underneath
- ☐ Large cat-style litter box, with a hay rack over it
- ☐ Paper-based or wood-pellet litter
- ☐ Grass hay, bought in bulk, stored dry and airy
- ☐ Plain timothy-based pellets, and a measuring cup
- ☐ Heavy ceramic water bowl, plus a bottle as a backup
- ☐ Hide or cardboard castle, and a platform to get on top of
- ☐ Dig box with soil, shredded paper, or hay
- ☐ Chew material: bamboo sticks, untreated willow, plain cardboard
- ☐ Nail clippers and styptic powder, comb or grooming mitt
- ☐ Carrier that opens from the top, not just the front
- ☐ Cable tubing and anything else the room needs proofing with
- ☐ Kitchen scale that reads in grams, for weekly weigh-ins

Before your rabbit comes home

- ☐ Room proofed, cables covered, and the pen set up before arrival
- ☐ Spay or neuter booked, or confirmed as already done (page 16)

Targets

TARGET	FIGURE
Enclosure space	8 sq ft (0.75 m ²) minimum
Exercise space	24 sq ft (2.2 m ²), 5+ hours a day, permanent access better
Room temperature	61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C), act at 77°F (25°C), never above 80°F (27°C). Cold: drafts, not degrees
Hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet
Greens	1 cup per 2 lb (1 kg) daily, 3+ varieties
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily
Treats	1 to 2 tbsp, once or twice a week
Vet exams	Twice a year, including the back teeth

Emergency & quick targets

VET TODAY IF

No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours · droppings small, misshapen, or fur-strung · hunched posture or audible tooth grinding · bloated or tense abdomen · fly eggs or maggots in the fur · drooling or dropping food · eye or nasal discharge with crusted front paws · head tilt or loss of balance · open-mouth breathing · straining to urinate · sudden lethargy or hiding · soft, unformed stool

READING	TARGET
Hay	Unlimited, 80 to 85% of the diet
Greens	1 cup per 2 lb (1 kg) daily, 3+ varieties
Pellets	1/8 to 1/4 cup per 5 to 6 lb (2.3 to 2.7 kg) daily
Room temperature	61 to 72°F (16 to 22°C), act at 77°F (25°C), never above 80°F (27°C). Cold: drafts, not degrees
Exercise	24 sq ft (2.2 m ²), 5+ hours a day minimum
The line	8 to 12 hours with no food or droppings is same-day, not overnight

Your numbers

Rabbit-savvy vet _____

Normal weight _____

Out-of-hours clinic that takes rabbits _____

Spayed or neutered on _____

Rabbit's name and date of birth _____

Last vaccination _____

SAY THIS WHEN YOU CALL

"Not eating, no droppings" gets a rabbit seen faster than "seems a bit off," and it is the accurate description. Have ready: when it last ate, when you last saw normal droppings, current weight and the trend, whether it is neutered, what changed recently, and any medication given.

THE ONE HABIT THAT CATCHES MOST OF THIS

A five-second look in the litter box every morning. Not counting, just noticing whether there are fewer than yesterday. It is the earliest signal this species gives you, and it is free.

Budget & shopping list

US retail ranges. The low end is basic but correct gear, the high end is premium.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
Foldable metal exercise pen	\$40 to \$100
Large cat-style litter box, plus a hay rack	\$5 to \$25
Food and water dishes, heavy ceramic	\$10 to \$20
Flooring: vinyl remnant or washable rugs, plus a tarp	\$20 to \$60
Hide, platform, and a dig box	\$20 to \$60
Nail clippers, comb or grooming mitt, styptic powder	\$15 to \$30
Top-opening carrier	\$20 to \$45
Cable tubing and rabbit-proofing supplies	\$15 to \$40
Kitchen scale in grams	\$10 to \$20
Equipment subtotal	\$155 to \$400
Spay or neuter, if not already done	\$150 to \$500
The rabbit: adoption, often including the surgery	\$25 to \$100
All-in, first month	\$330 to \$1,000

Fuller setups reach \$600 in equipment alone. Low-cost nonprofit spay and neuter programs sometimes come in around \$139 to \$150, and a rabbit rescue will know which are near you.

MONTHLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Hay, the bulk of the diet	\$20 to \$40
Fresh vegetables	\$15 to \$50
Litter	\$15 to \$25
Pellets	\$5 to \$15
Wellness exams, two a year averaged	\$10 to \$17
Monthly ongoing	\$65 to \$147

Food and litter alone typically run \$60 to \$100 a month. A realistic annual total after year one is \$500 to \$800; year one runs \$1,000 to \$1,500 once setup and the surgery are counted.

KEEP THIS SEPARATE FROM THE BUDGET ABOVE

An emergency fund of \$500 to \$1,000. A single GI stasis workup can exceed \$1,500, and rabbits need an exotic vet whose rates run above a general clinic's. This is the line item that decides whether an emergency is survivable or a decision, and it is worth having before the rabbit arrives.

First 30 days checklist

Before day 1

- ☐ Pen up, room proofed, cables covered, and the litter box already stocked with hay over it
- ☐ A week's worth of whatever the rabbit is currently eating, so nothing changes on day one
- ☐ Rabbit-savvy exotic vet found and the number written on page 27
- ☐ Out-of-hours clinic that will see a rabbit identified, with the distance known

Day 1

- ☐ Set the carrier down in the pen, open it, and walk away. Let the rabbit come out in its own time
- ☐ No handling, no visitors, no other pets in the room. Hay, water, and quiet
- ☐ Weigh in grams and photograph the rabbit as a baseline
- ☐ Fill in the numbers on page 27 and the equipment dates on page 36

Week 1

- ☐ Check the litter box every morning. You are establishing what normal output looks like for this rabbit
- ☐ Sit on the floor nearby for a while each day without reaching for the rabbit. That is the whole exercise
- ☐ Book the first wellness exam, and confirm the spay or neuter status and vaccination history
- ☐ Keep the diet exactly as it was. Change nothing yet

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin transitioning hay, pellets, or greens to your chosen brands, mixing old with new over a week or two
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 35 with a weekly weigh-in
- ☐ Introduce greens one variety at a time, watching for soft stool for two days before adding the next
- ☐ Extend run time toward permanent access as the rabbit's confidence grows

Week 4

- ☐ Review the log for weight trend and output. Steady weight and plentiful even droppings is the goal
- ☐ First nail trim, and a proper hands-on check: incisors, jawline, hocks, rear end
- ☐ Add enrichment from page 37, one change at a time

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book the spay or neuter if it is not done, and read page 16 before you choose the clinic
- ☐ Start thinking seriously about a companion, and read page 15 before you bring one home
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet on page 34 before you need it
- ☐ Confirm the out-of-hours clinic on page 27 still takes rabbits, and how far it actually is

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
No food or droppings for 8 to 12 hours	GI stasis	Rabbit vet today. Say "not eating, no droppings" (page 18)
Fewer or smaller droppings than yesterday	Early stasis or dehydration	Push hay and water, watch closely, call if it continues (page 25)
Hunched, belly tucked, harsh tooth grinding	Abdominal pain	Vet today. Grinding here is pain, not contentment (page 18)
Drooling, dropping food, damp chin	Dental disease	Vet. The back teeth need sedation to see (page 21)
Fly eggs or maggots in the fur	Flystrike	Emergency vet now, at any hour. Do not soak the rabbit (page 22)
Nasal or eye discharge, crusted front paws	Snuffles	Vet, and ask for a culture before antibiotics (page 22)
Head tilt, rolling, loss of balance	<i>E. cuniculi</i> or inner ear infection	Vet promptly. Earlier treatment, better outcome (page 23)
Open-mouth breathing	Airway obstruction or respiratory failure	Emergency, same hour. Rabbits breathe through the nose (page 22)
Straining to urinate, gritty or bloody urine	Bladder sludge or stones	Vet today. Review calcium in the diet after (page 23)
Bald or red patches on the undersides of the hind feet	Sore hocks	Soften the flooring now, vet if the skin is open (page 23)
Soft cecotropes stuck to fur or floor	Too many pellets or treats, or can't reach	Cut pellets and sugar first, then check weight and mobility (page 25)
Truly soft, unformed stool	Diarrhea, rare and serious in adults	Vet today, same day in a young rabbit (page 25)
Panting, hot ears, lying flat and unwilling to move	Heatstroke	Cool the ears with a damp cloth, move somewhere cool, call the vet (page 7)
Thumping, freezing, hiding constantly	Stress, or too little space and no companion	Look at pages 5, 14 and 15, 13 and 14 before looking at the rabbit
Weight loss between weekly weigh-ins	Several possible causes, dental first	Vet, and bring the Owner Log (page 35)
Urine spraying, mounting, sudden aggression	Intact hormones	Spay or neuter. This is not a training problem (page 16)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Daily

- ☐ Look in the litter box. Quantity and shape, five seconds
- ☐ Top up hay so it is never empty, and refresh the water
- ☐ Measured pellets and the day's greens, at least three varieties
- ☐ Spot-clean the litter box and any accidents
- ☐ Run time, ideally permanent, and at dawn and dusk if it is not
- ☐ Thirty seconds of watching: posture, breathing, eyes, appetite, how it moves

Weekly

- ☐ Weigh in grams and log it on page 35
- ☐ Full litter box change and a wipe-down of the pen floor
- ☐ Hands-on check: incisors, jawline, hocks, rear end, lumps
- ☐ Brush, and daily instead during a molt

Every 6 to 8 weeks

- ☐ Nail trim, both feet, with styptic powder to hand
- ☐ Scent gland clean with a damp cotton bud
- ☐ Deep clean the pen, and restock hay in bulk

Monthly

- ☐ Review the log for slow trends rather than single readings
- ☐ Rotate or add one piece of enrichment from page 37
- ☐ Re-check the room for new chew hazards, especially after any furniture moves

Seasonal

- ☐ Spring and autumn: heavy molts. Brush daily and push hay and water hard
- ☐ Summer: check the rear end daily for flystrike, and watch the room temperature
- ☐ Winter: keep the room from dropping, and watch water intake, which falls when it is cold

Twice a year

- ☐ Wellness exam, and ask specifically for the back teeth
- ☐ RHDV2 vaccination on your vet's schedule, annually in the US

TWO WELLNESS EXAMS A YEAR

Not one. A twice-yearly check with a rabbit-experienced vet catches dental changes, weight drift, and early kidney or bladder trouble well before any of it becomes the emergency it would otherwise become. Ask specifically for the back teeth to be examined, since the molar spurs that cause most dental pain are not visible from the front.

Power outages & the blackout plan

A rabbit needs no equipment running to survive, which makes a blackout mostly a temperature problem.

When the power goes out

Do

- Keep feeding normally. This is the one animal in this series where the blackout advice is to carry on: a rabbit that stops eating for a day is in more danger than one that is a bit cold.
- In a cold outage, add deep bedding, a cardboard box stuffed with hay to sit inside, and a wrapped hot-water bottle placed beside the rabbit rather than under it. Raise the pen off the floor, where the coldest air sits, keep it away from windows and doors, and check the water has not frozen, including the ball in a bottle nozzle.
- In a hot outage, move to the coolest room in the house, usually a tiled bathroom or a basement, add airflow if you have a battery fan, and give a frozen water bottle wrapped in a towel to lie against. Water-heavy foods help: cucumber, melon and apple.
- Keep water available in more than one container and check it more often, since a rabbit drinking less is the start of the problem on page 18.
- Move the rabbit out rather than wait, once the room is past the band on page 7 and you have no way to bring it back. That is a decision to make at hour two, not hour eight, because a house without power has all day to keep heating up.

Don't

- Don't use candles or an open flame anywhere a rabbit can reach or knock into.
- Don't put a heat source in direct contact with the rabbit.
- Don't move a bonded pair apart to make handling easier. Keep them together.

OUTAGE KIT

A wrapped hot-water bottle, two freezer blocks, a battery fan, a torch, spare bedding, and the numbers from page 27.

Travel, transport & moving

A rabbit travels badly and notices every change, so the planning matters more than the equipment.

Leaving town

TRIP LENGTH	WHAT TO DO
1 night	Possible with a big hay pile, fresh water in two containers, and a full litter box, but only for a healthy adult and only if you accept that nobody will notice a stasis episode. A visit is better.
2 to 4 nights	A sitter every day without exception. The daily litter box check is the whole reason, and it cannot be skipped for a rabbit.
Over 4 nights	A daily sitter who has done a practice visit with you, or boarding with a rabbit-experienced rescue or vet. Leave page 34 filled in and the vet informed that someone else may bring the rabbit in.

Transport and vet trips

- A hard carrier that opens from the top as well as the front, so a frightened rabbit can be lifted out with support rather than dragged. Line it with a towel over a non-slip mat, and add a handful of unsoiled bedding from home so it smells right.
- Drape a towel over most of the carrier. A rabbit is a prey animal and an open view of a car park is a stream of predators walking past, so somewhere to hide beats somewhere to look out.
- Put hay and a couple of favorite greens in for every journey, including the trip to the vet, and offer water. A rabbit that eats in the carrier is a rabbit whose gut kept moving.
- Secure the carrier with a seatbelt in the footwell or on a seat, with its side facing the direction of travel so a hard stop does not throw the rabbit face first into the end. Keep it out of direct sun and drive as smoothly as you can. Never in the boot of a car, and never left in a parked one.
- Take a bonded partner along even when only one is ill. Separating a pair, even for an afternoon, can break the bond, and the companion calms the patient.
- Moving house: set the pen up in a quiet room before anything else is unpacked, keep the diet identical for a fortnight, and watch output closely for a week. A move is a classic stasis trigger.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE PEN

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Rabbit's name _____

Normal weight, and where the food is _____

My phone _____

Rabbit-savvy vet _____

Out-of-hours clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Every visit, every day

- ☐ **Look in the litter box first.** There should be a lot of round droppings, roughly pea-sized. Write down roughly how many compared with yesterday. This is the most important thing on this sheet.
- ☐ Top up hay so the rack and box are full. There is no such thing as too much hay.
- ☐ Fresh water. Wash the bowl rather than topping it up.
- ☐ Measured pellets: _____ per day, and the greens left in the fridge. No other food, no treats.
- ☐ Scoop the litter box and any accidents.
- ☐ Sit with the rabbit for a few minutes and watch it. It should be moving around, curious, and eating.

Please don't

- Feed anything not on this sheet. Bread, crackers, cereal, yogurt drops, and iceberg lettuce are all harmful here, whatever the packet says.
- Pick the rabbit up unless we have agreed on it. If you must, support the chest and the back end at the same time and stay low to the ground.
- Flip the rabbit onto its back. It looks calm and it is not.
- Let the rabbit into any room I have not shown you. Cables are the danger.
- Separate a bonded pair, even briefly.

CALL ME STRAIGHT AWAY IF

There are noticeably fewer droppings than yesterday, or none at all · the rabbit has not touched its food · it is sitting hunched with its belly tucked in, or grinding its teeth loudly · its belly looks bloated or feels tense · there is discharge from the eyes or nose · it is drooling or dropping food · it is breathing with its mouth open · its head is tilted to one side · there is anything crawling in its fur, or any wet, dirty patch around its back end · it is lying flat and will not move

Owner log

One row a week, filled in on weigh-in day. Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	DROPPINGS	HAY EATEN	APPETITE	GROOMING, BEHAVIOR, ANYTHING NOTICED

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

Weight is the earliest number that moves. Dental disease, kidney trouble, and most of Section 03 show up as a slow decline in grams weeks before anything is visible, and nobody notices a slow decline by eye. Sixteen rows is four months, which is long enough to see a real trend rather than a bad week.

Equipment, vet & bonding log

Care task log

TASK	LAST DONE	DUE	DONE
Nail trim, every 6 to 8 weeks			
Scent gland clean			
Pen deep clean			
Hay restock			
RHDV2 vaccination			

Twelve-month planner

Tick the box in the month you did it. Start with whichever month you're in.

TASK	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
Weigh and review the log	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Nail trim	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Pen deep clean	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Wellness exam	☐					☐						
Vaccination	☐											☐

Bonding log

DATE	SESSION LENGTH	HOW IT WENT: CHASING, MOUNTING, GROOMING, RESTING IN CONTACT

Vet visit log

DATE	WEIGHT (G)	REASON AND FINDINGS, INCLUDING THE DENTAL CHECK	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist & log

Setup

- ☐ A neutered, bonded companion, close in age (page 15)
- ☐ Permanent run access, or a rabbit-proofed room
- ☐ Hay in tubes, bundles, and racks so eating it takes time
- ☐ A dig box with soil, shredded paper, or hay
- ☐ A platform to get on top of, and cover to get underneath

Monthly review

- ☐ Move or add one item, without taking away a hiding place
- ☐ Scatter greens through hay or a snuffle mat instead of putting them in a bowl
- ☐ Restock chew material: bamboo, untreated willow, plain cardboard
- ☐ Check the rabbit is using more of the space than last month, not less

Enrichment log

DATE	WHAT CHANGED	HOW IT WENT, AND WHETHER TO REPEAT

WHAT NOT TO DO

Don't buy toys instead of solving space or company: the research measured that gap and toys were not what closed it. Don't take away a hiding place to add a new object. Don't change three things at once, or you will never know which one the rabbit responded to. And don't read a still, quiet rabbit in a small pen as a contented one, because awake inactivity is exactly what the companionship study measured.

Glossary

Awake inactivity	Sitting still while awake for long stretches. A welfare measure rather than a mood, and associated in the research with solitary or confined housing.
Bonded pair	Two rabbits that have been properly introduced and now live together, groom each other, and rest in contact. Separating them, even briefly, can break the bond.
Bruxism	Tooth grinding. Soft and quiet means a contented rabbit; harsh and audible means pain, and the two are easy to tell apart once you have heard both.
Cecotropes	Soft, dark, clustered droppings produced overnight and eaten directly from the source. A genuine part of digestion, not a problem.
Crepuscular	Most active at dawn and dusk. It is why permanent run access beats an hour scheduled for the household's convenience.
Dewlap	The fold of skin under the chin, larger in does. A permanently damp dewlap points at drooling, and so at dental disease.
Doe and buck	Female and male rabbit.
Dystocia	Difficulty giving birth. One more reason an unsprayed doe carries risk a spayed one does not.
<i>E. cuniculi</i>	<i>Encephalitozoon cuniculi</i> , a parasite many pet rabbits carry silently. When active it causes head tilt, kidney disease, or cataracts.
Flystrike	Fly eggs laid in soiled fur hatching into maggots that eat into the skin. Can kill within 24 to 48 hours.
GI stasis	The gut slowing or stopping. The most common life-threatening emergency in pet rabbits, and the reason for the 8-hour rule.
Hindgut fermenter	An animal that digests fiber in the cecum, after the small intestine. It is why the gut must keep moving and why fiber is not optional.
Kit	A baby rabbit.
Molar spur	A sharp point on an overgrown back tooth that cuts the tongue or cheek. Not visible from the front, which is why the dental exam needs sedation.
Pododermatitis	Sore hocks: pressure sores on the underside of the hind feet, caused by wire or hard flooring, damp, or obesity.
RHDV2	Rabbit Haemorrhagic Disease Virus type 2. Highly contagious, often fatal, and survives on shoes, clothing, and hay. Vaccinate.
Snuffles	Upper respiratory infection, most often <i>Pasteurella multocida</i> . Look for crusted front paws as much as for a runny nose.
Trancing	Flipping a rabbit onto its back until it goes still. Measured heart rate and stress hormones show this is fear, not relaxation. Don't.
X-pen	A foldable metal exercise pen. The current standard for rabbit housing, in place of a cage or hutch.

REFERENCE

Sources & further reading

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary manuals and clinical references

- Merck Veterinary Manual, *Housing of Rabbits*, for the 61 to 72°F optimal environment and the cold tolerance note on page 7.
- Merck Veterinary Manual, *Management of Rabbits*, for the fasting rule and the 2 to 3 hour post-operative eating bar on page 16.
- Merck Veterinary Manual, *Providing a Home for a Rabbit*, for the molt pattern and the brushing intervals on page 24.
- VCA Animal Hospitals, *Health Problems in Rabbits*, for the 80°F ceiling on pages 7, 26 and 27, and for why a rabbit that cannot vomit needs surgery for a true blockage.
- Lafeber Co., *Tips for Grooming Your Rabbit*, for the 6 to 8 week nail and scent gland interval and the technique on page 24.
- RSPCA, *Transporting Your Rabbits*, for the carrier, hiding, hay and in-car placement guidance on page 33.
- PDSA winter guidance for rabbits and guinea pigs, for the cold-outage shelter, bedding and frozen-water checks on page 32.
- Rabbit Welfare Association & Fund, *Bathing Rabbits*, for the fracture risk behind the no-bathing rule on page 24.

Research

- Companionship counts: investigating social housing conditions and welfare in privately owned rabbits. *Applied Animal Behaviour Science*.
- Run access, hutch size and time-of-day affect welfare-relevant behaviour and faecal corticosterone in pair-housed pet rabbits. *Applied Animal Behaviour Science*.
- Do rabbits need each other? Effects of single versus paired housing on rabbit body temperature and behaviour in a UK shelter. *Animal Welfare*.
- The use of environmental enrichments affects performance and behavior of growing rabbits housed in collective pens.

Husbandry references

- House Rabbit Society (rabbit.org), for the space standard on page 5, the diet proportions on pages 8 to 10, and the GI stasis guidance in Section 03.
- PetMD, Gastrointestinal (GI) Stasis in Rabbits, for the presentation and treatment on pages 18 and 20, including the recovery figure.
- Wisconsin Humane Society, litter box training your rabbit, for the method on page 6.
- FurCalc rabbit feeding calculator, for the portion figures cross-checked on page 9.
- Beastly Facts rabbit guides: housing, feeding, GI stasis, health issues, handling, cost, and enrichment, plus the small mammal guides on temperature and heat stress, grooming and nails, and vet visits and travel. Current at the time of publication.

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed, and when, so you can tell which edition you are holding.

VERSION	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
2.1 · Sep 2026	t3	Corrections edition from a cross-check against the small mammal articles published in September 2026. The temperature page moves to Merck's 61 to 72°F optimal range and VCA's 80°F ceiling, which now also appear on the checklist and the emergency card alongside the cold guidance. Heat stress signs gain drooling in their proper place. Nail and scent gland intervals move to Lafeber's 6 to 8 weeks. The molt page carries Merck's unpredictable pattern and stops describing swallowed fur as a direct cause of stasis. Fasting before surgery and the post-operative eating deadline move to Merck's figures. The GI stasis line reads 8 to 12 hours everywhere rather than 8 on five pages. Outages and travel gain the RSPCA and PDSA detail. Sources and version history split onto two pages. 40 pages.
2.0 · Sep 2026	t3	Rebuilt on the t3 package template at 39 pages, adapted to a mammal layout: the reptile heat and UVB pages replaced with indoors versus outdoors and temperature, and two pages given to GI stasis, one to dental disease, and one each to bonding and to spay and neuter. Adds a droppings and cecotrope reference, a grooming and molt page, and both units throughout.
1.0 · Sep 2026	pre-t3	First edition, on the earlier 22-page package layout.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the sources on page 39 and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a rabbit-savvy exotic veterinarian, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit. Free companion guides, updated as guidance changes, are at beastlyfacts.com.

© Beastly Facts · Version 2.1 · Template t3 · September 2026 · For personal use by the purchaser. Please don't redistribute.